



at least seven or eight years.”

Considering his family background, the fact that Keymer took up chess and stuck with it is a surprising twist of fate.

“Let’s put it this way: chess sought out Vincent; not the other way around,” said German chess coach Bernd Vokler in 2015 to *Focus* magazine, having witnessed Keymer’s growth from close quarters.

Keymer picked up a chessboard by chance when he was five and was taught the rules by his parents. Spoiler alert — it didn’t take long for him to beat them.

“Chess doesn’t really run in the family. I was just a child being curious about what it was. It could have been any other game as well. I think you can call it fate in some way. I really liked it from the start. Turns out I had some talent for it,” says Keymer.

The next stage of his chess

lessons came from a local club in Saulheim, his hometown, relying on DVD tutorials. Winning the regional tournament was only a natural progression, and soon he was garnering appreciation from the likes of Kasparov.

While fate got him into chess, Keymer made sure the sport remained fun for him — something he advocates to prevent young players from burning out early.

“It’s important that children like playing chess. Of course, you can also make great chess players by pushing someone to certain limits. But then you will often realise they end up quitting at a young age because it’s not their true passion. At a certain point, you need to give so much of your life to chess that if you don’t really enjoy it, you just don’t do it,” points out Keymer.

While he has undoubtedly earned his position in the global chess scene, the biggest boost to his profile — at

Focus mode on: Vincent Keymer in action at the recently concluded Chennai Grand Masters. VELANKANNIRAJ

least in India — came thanks to his role as a second for D. Gukesh during the Indian’s title win at the World Championship final in 2024.

“He [Gukesh] texted me when I was in Malmo for a tournament. He said he wanted to talk to me personally. I really appreciated him having the conversation directly, and not through a manager or coach.

I think that was important because it’s about professionalism. You need a good atmosphere in the team, and I need to feel like I really want to give my 100 per cent support to him for that match,” says Keymer.

While working with Gukesh gave him a peripheral view of the long drawn out and tense nature of a World Championship, Keymer believes the experience hasn’t